REPUBLIC OF BOTSWANA

Guest of Honour Speech by Hon. Thulagano Merafe Segokgo Minister of Communications, Knowledge and Technology (MCKT) delivered during 8th National ICT Summit

Held on 9th – 11th September 2024, Windhoek, Namibia.

Hon. Emma Theofelus, Minister of ICT

Hon. Laura McLeod-Katjirua, Governor of Khomas Region

Ms. Doreen Bogdan-Martin, ITU Secretary General

Distinguished Guests

Captains of the Industry

Members of the Media

Ladies and Gentlemen

Ladies and Gentlemen,

1. A very good morning to you all.
2. I wish to begin by thanking much very much the Namibian Government for hosting this important 8th National ICT Summit. I am very humbled by your invitation allowing me to be the Guest Honour. We have a lot in common between our two countries. We cherish the same aspirations in particular the attainment of digitalisation of our economies. From the onset, I wish to state that what we have accomplished thus far in terms of digitalisation forms a basis for achieving more between our countries. There is great opportunity for instance, for a single digital market between our two countries wherein we can trade in digital products and services. We can extend our global reach through the same digital infrastructure. In our deliberations at today's Summit and beyond it, I wish to see more areas for collaboration and cooperation between our two countries and beyond, being identified and followed through with robust efforts over a defined period.
3. Having perused through the agenda of the Summit, I am very confident discussions will enrich our developmental agenda. It

would then be very important that we deliberate with the strategic objective of accomplishing clear outcomes that will lead to a true transformation agenda over the next few years. For instance, we note that new ICT help transform traditional cities to smart cities featuring integrated governance. Necessarily that new ICTs are able to grant us this pivotal opportunity, does not translate to such benefits accruing in our economies. There are some actions we need to undertake. We need to deliberate in our efforts commencing with revamping our policy, legal and regulatory frameworks to deliver on such intended outcomes. I dare say, we need to qualify these digitalisation outcomes as increased productivity and efficiency in all sectors, employment and self-employment, increased revenues for businesses, individuals and Governments, increased opportunities for all including the marginalised. I therefore urge us all to focus our deliberations to accomplishment of such noble outcomes. These can only be realised if all sectors of the economy being digitalised including those which traditional have been shy of adopting and adapting technologies in delivery of their services.

4. Ladies and Gentlemen, we can learn a lot from other countries that have already advanced in digitalisation. Of these countries, some have adopted at the top-end to be innovation hubs and therefore their efforts are characterised by focus on specific areas that enable them to conceptualise and commercialise new technologies and solutions. Some have opted to be service powerhouse wherein they focus in development of software, content and services delivery. Majority of our countries in Africa unfortunately are limited to the lower end, where some of us are have just begun adopting ICTs and value creation, and a few of us already are using and consuming ICT highly but value creation is limited. However, we can quickly convert this unfortunate situation into a positive one by deliberately to formulating new strategies applicable to our context with the strategic intent of tapping into the latent potent we have in Africa. We have the numbers, we have the resources that if we use appropriately can easily position us as a global. We therefore must show ambition and zeal to accomplish this feat.
5. Ladies and Gentlemen, how we then allocate scarce resources and finite funds is especially fundamental beyond the scourge

of COVID-19. Our economies are under pressure to deliver on our aspirations. We count on dialogue such as the one we are having today to develop solutions on all spheres including policy. We note a disheartening aspect that our economies are not integrated with the global ICT value chain.

6. Ladies and Gentlemen, further to these, we are well aware that exploitation of Open Data as a commodity requires managing data as an asset for economic transformation. This will lead to agriculture improvement, preventative health actions, road safety, emergency response, encouragement of startups and entrepreneurs, identifying fraud patterns in public acquisitions as few examples. These would in turn lead to benefits such as Smart Government impacting positively on public service improvement. We would truly realise communities collaboration as in citizens, industry, government departments. We would further realise government transparency, improved policies and accountability. Furthermore, we would achieve crowd source information for analytics that can be used in disease management, education and the economy. However, history shows that our economies have been hinged on Governments

as the main driver. Therefore, we need to adopt policies that lead to the release of these essential data in the hands of Governments to oil our economies. The data needs to be refined to be useful.

7. Ladies and Gentlemen, as I move towards concluding my speech, I would like to share with you the Botswana story that I am grateful to say Namibia our sister country has contributed to. In line with Vision 2036, His Excellency the President is driving Digital Transformation and Mindset Change to rally the nation to embrace the digital way of life and adopt a global perspective to life. Botswana has made some commendable strides in the digitalisation drive for the country. Notably, we have more than four million mobile subscriptions, 94% mobile broadband population coverage, in excess of 16000km of optical fibre in a mesh format connecting major destinations and smaller ones. This optical fibre at the backbone layer is coupled with optical fibre that has been rolled out to essential facilities in all our cities, towns and major villages. These essential facilities include our hospitals, schools, Government offices, clinics, *dikgotla*. We have a programme of connecting the underserved

and unserved areas of rural Botswana. This is ongoing and is done in phases.

8. Our policy and legal framework encourages foreign direct investments. We have connectivity to the rest of the world through undersea cable systems in the Indian Ocean and in the Atlantic Ocean. We have invested co-jointly with Namibia on the landing station on the Atlantic Ocean and the transit link to our borders. Botswana's judiciary is renowned for protecting all. These are some of the positive indicators we take pride in. We are a country you could invest in with assurance that your business can only grow.
9. We are working on developing policies and regulatory instruments that will foster adoption of 4IR Technologies that include Artificial Intelligence, Robotics and Internet of Things amongst others. As I had indicated, Botswana desires not to be left behind with the advent of 4IR. We aim to achieve positive economic outlook through digitalisation of all sectors. In this agenda, we are also worry of imminent cyber threats and we are now catapulting cybersecurity infrastructure to protect our critical national information infrastructure that our economic,

social and security interests are heavily reliant on. A significant budget has been put aside for essential research, research that is necessary to develop our innovation capability and capacity.

10. I wish to close my remarks by encouraging all us all to engage with full intellect in the discourse of the Summit. We are reliant on you who will be joining the deliberations physically and virtually to bring out the ideas that will help shape our destiny.

11. On that note, it is my pleasure to once again welcome you to today's session and I wish you fruitful deliberations.

12. I thank you for your kind attention.

Pula !!!! Pula!!!!